



Ballot battle: NSUI workers distributing pamphlets before the Delhi University students' elections

No Engagement

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ourselves with public policies. We see our role of "citizen" through a limited lens—paying taxes and obeying laws. Our political identity of "voter" is supremely undervalued. We are comfortable forming networks to engage in music, religion, business, rotary, social service, but are uncomfortable about engaging in politics. We shun politics with an unusual righteousness and starve our youth of civic role models.

Undoubtedly, voting for individual candidates with charisma—a Clinton, Obama, or Palin—is so much more inspiring than voting for parties. In India, we are denied the opportunity to vote for our mayors, our chief ministers, our governors or our prime ministers. We are constrained to vote for parties that decide for us who will occupy these positions, effectively shifting the power equation from the people to the party. But this is an insufficient reason to disengage from defining our politics.

The protestation that corrupt candidates turn us off voting has become something of a convenient copout. Perhaps, we do not have good enough candidates because there are not enough good voters who care enough to cast their votes. Clearly, our change is not going to be led by individual messiahs. But do we believe that one billion voices are powerless? Let's not get trapped into a nirvana fallacy, waiting for perfect conditions before we are willing to play our rightful role in India's political journey.

We need somebody to play centre-forward. Our youthful demographic dividend has been hailed as an economic positive. Let's also consider it a democratic positive. Turning 18 can become a milestone not just because it allows you a driver's licence, but also because it allows you the licence to vote. Will the youth lead our one billion voices out of political indifference? This could be the small step towards citizenship and a giant leap for our democracy.

We live in a country that demands so little from our citizens. Over 20 countries, including Australia, have introduced compulsory voting for its citizens. Singapore enrolls all male citizens upon reaching 18 years, to a mandatory two years in national service under the Singapore Armed Forces. Jury duty is mandatory in the US and can be deferred only twice. During times of war, all able young men have to register for the draft. We demand absolutely nothing of our citizens, of our youth, for the privilege of citizenship.

The spirit of service is what drives tall leaders around the world to do great things and average citizens to commit to causes of common good. It inspires individuals to look beyond themselves and empower others.

But in order to empower others we must be empowered ourselves. Let's begin with the simple act of voting.

The author is the co-founder of a volunteer service.